

A DIFFERENT APPROACH

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Maintain a program of recovery free from impulsive behavior and addiction.
2. Reduce the frequency of impulsive behavior and increase the frequency of behavior that is carefully thought out.
3. Learn to stop, think, and plan before acting.
4. Learn self-observation skills to identify patterns of impulsive behavior.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE IMPULSIVITY

- Alternatives to Addictive Behavior
- Analyzing Acting-Out Behavior
- Early Warning Signs of Mania/Hypomania
- Early Warning Signs of Relapse
- From Recklessness to Calculated Risks
- Handling Crisis
- Planning for Stability
- What Do I Want for My Children?
- What Price Am I Willing to Pay?

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Attention Deficit Disorder, Inattentive Type (ADD)
- Attention-Deficit/Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD)
- Suicidal Ideation

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “A Different Approach” activity is designed for the client who would benefit from observing his/her own behavior, assessing it, and developing and implementing new behavioral approaches. It may be useful to work through a few of the exercises together in the therapy session, have the client practice alternative coping methods outside the session, and record the results. You may or may not want to give the example provided until the client has worked through one successfully on his/her own. If a client gets stuck, you may want to show video clips of people acting impulsively (e.g., from

television programs or popular films) and walk through the steps with him/her regarding the characters in the clips. Many times the outcome of impulsive behavior is positive in the short-term, but the long-term consequences or secondary gains are negative. The goal is to get the client to improve his/her insight regarding achieving desired outcomes with fewer negative returns.

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Impulsivity means having difficulty resisting urges or delaying behavior. Some people think of it as being impatient or not thinking things through. Acting impulsively can cause social, legal, academic, relationship, work-related, and other types of problems. It can lead to physical fights, addictive behavior, and alienation from others. Acting and reacting less impulsively is a skill that you can learn and use to avoid these painful consequences and to get the outcomes you desire. Acting less impulsively involves two components: first, it requires being able to observe your own behavior. Second, it involves developing self-management skills. This exercise will help you work through the steps of self-observation and think through ways to get what you want without the painful consequences that often accompany acting without thinking first.

1. Choose a situation, recently or some time ago, in which you acted impulsively. You may want to select an event related to your addiction, since this is often connected with acting impulsively. Describe that event in the following format:

- a. What happened first?

- b. Then what?

- c. What next?

- d. Next?

- e. Next, and so on to its conclusion?

2. Now assess your motivation for your behavior by asking yourself, “What did I want to have happen? What was the purpose of this behavior?”

3. Third, finish analyzing the consequences by asking yourself, “What were the outcomes or results of this behavior?” and, “Were they what I wanted to happen?”

4. Assess for alternatives. Ask yourself, “What else could I have done to get what I wanted?” List as many other options as you can think of.

5. Last, pick one alternative and specifically identify five actions you will need to take to practice this alternative.

Be sure to bring this handout to your next therapy session, and be prepared to talk about your questions, thoughts, and feelings about the exercise.